NBS-7170A Assignment Guide and Plan

Oct 17, 2026 · @Syed Zulkifal Banuri

What the assignment is really testing

The 1,250-word report is what gets marked, and it is a reflection and critique of your design choices. A working MySQL database is the evidence behind it, not the thing being graded. Submission is **17 December 2026, 15:00** (40% of the module); the target here is to finish by **Sunday 29 November**.

Marking criterion	Weight	What it rewards
Cognitive and intellectual skills	35%	Arguing why you made each choice, weighing trade-offs, admitting limits of your data and schema
Subject knowledge and understanding	25%	Theory and academic citations: CRISP-DM, relational design, GenAI in analytics
Practical skills	25%	ERM, MySQL, SQL, Python and an API, done accurately
Transferable and digital skills	15%	Clear communication and a visualisation of your query results

Three things that could cost marks

1. **Dataset approval.** Your tutor must approve the dataset before you use it. Sort this in week one, because everything else depends on it.
2. **Weekly IT Lab check-ins.** Failing to engage can cost up to **50% of your grade**. Attending and showing progress is part of the assignment.
3. **References.** You need 10–15 good academic sources in Harvard style; reputable websites can replace a few. The word limit includes in-text citations but not the reference list.

Report structure and word budget

The limit is 1,250 words; the 10% tolerance allows about 1,375, but aim for 1,250 so you are not relying on it. Every claim in the process section should read: I chose X because Y, the trade-off was Z, and the limitation is W.

Section	Words	Content
Introduction	150	The case study, the business problem, and why a relational database helps
Process	900	ERM to relational schema; MySQL; SQL (create, populate, query); Python (wrangling, loading, connecting); how an API could expose the database; GenAI supporting CRISP-DM stages
Decision support	200	How the database supports real decisions, and the limits of the data and schema

Put the ERM diagram, schema screenshots, sample queries and your visualisation in appendices. They do not count towards the word limit, but each must be labelled and named in the text, for example "see Appendix A".

Plan: finish by Sunday 29 November

Six weeks of work leave a buffer of about two and a half weeks before the 17 December deadline.

Week	Dates	Goal	Output
1	17–25 Oct	Read the case study closely and get dataset approval; start collecting sources; set up MySQL and Python	Approved dataset, list of business questions the database must answer, 5 sources
2	26 Oct–1 Nov	Draw the ERM: entities, attributes, relationships, keys, normalisation to 3NF	ERM diagram and notes on design decisions you would defend

Week	Dates	Goal	Output
3	2–8 Nov	Build the schema in MySQL with CREATE TABLE, constraints and foreign keys; clean data in Python and load it	Working populated database and SQL scripts
4	9–15 Nov	Write 4–6 business queries (joins, aggregations); connect from Python; produce one visualisation; sketch the API	Query outputs, chart, screenshots for appendices
5	16–22 Nov	Write the full first draft from your design-decision notes; finish reading (10–15 references)	Complete draft of about 1,300 words
6	23–29 Nov	Cut to the word limit, tighten the critique, check Harvard references, proofread, check against the four marking criteria	Submission-ready report and appendices
Buffer	30 Nov–17 Dec	Fix problems, ask your tutor questions, submit early	Nothing planned

How to work through it

- **Keep a design-decision log from week 2.** Whenever you choose something (one-to-many versus many-to-many, a data type, a normalisation step), write one line on why and what you gave up. Most of the 900 words can come from this log.
- **Take something to every IT Lab.** A schema sketch, a failing query or a Python connection script is enough. It protects against the 50% deduction and catches design errors early.
- **Note limitations as you hit them.** Data gaps, bias, small sample size and schema weaknesses are hard to remember later.
- **Use GenAI openly and critically.** The brief asks for the principles of using GenAI to support CRISP-DM stages. Try it for cleaning or generating SQL, and record where it helped and where you had to correct it.
- **Check the Blackboard guidance** on Harvard referencing and the UEA PG coursework criteria.